

WEST AFRICA

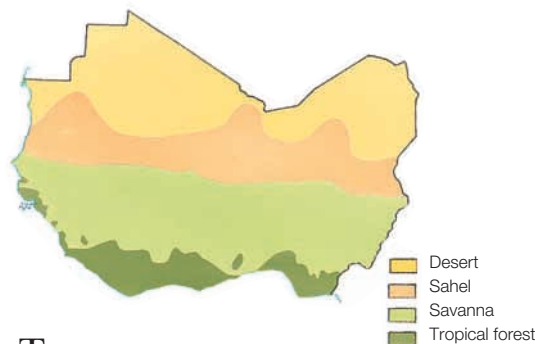
MANY CENTURIES AGO, great civilizations such as the Ashanti and Mali were thriving in the region now known as West Africa. Word of rich gold deposits brought Europeans flocking here, and by the 1880s they had colonized nearly all of this vast region. West Africa did not win back its independence until the 1960s. Although this region is rich in oil, gold, lumber, and other natural resources, most of the 15 countries in West Africa are very poor. There are large numbers of ethnic groups here – more than 200 different peoples in Nigeria alone. The combination of poverty and clashes between different peoples has made political turmoil another all-too-familiar feature of the region.



RELIGION

West Africa divides roughly into northern and southern regions where the landscape and climate are concerned, and this also applies to its religions. Islam is dominant in the north, while there are more Christians in the south. Throughout the region, many people follow ancient traditional religions such as voodoo, which is especially strong in Benin.

Climate zones in West Africa



THE CLIMATE

If you were to set out on a journey from north to south across this huge region, you would pass through a fascinating variety of hot, tropical landscapes. The vegetation of each zone has developed because of the amount of rain that falls there. Plenty of rain falls in the far south, whereas the arid northerly region is prone to serious drought. In some parts, there is a distinct wet season that lasts about 4–6 months, but no rain at all falls for much of the rest of the year.



There are many nomadic cattle herders in Burkina Faso, which lies in the dry sahel region.



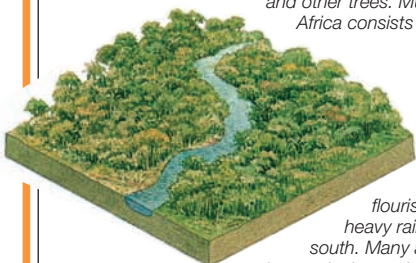
Desert
The burning Sahara forms the northern "lid" of West Africa. Very little grows here. The border of the desert advances or retreats, depending on how dry it becomes in neighboring areas.



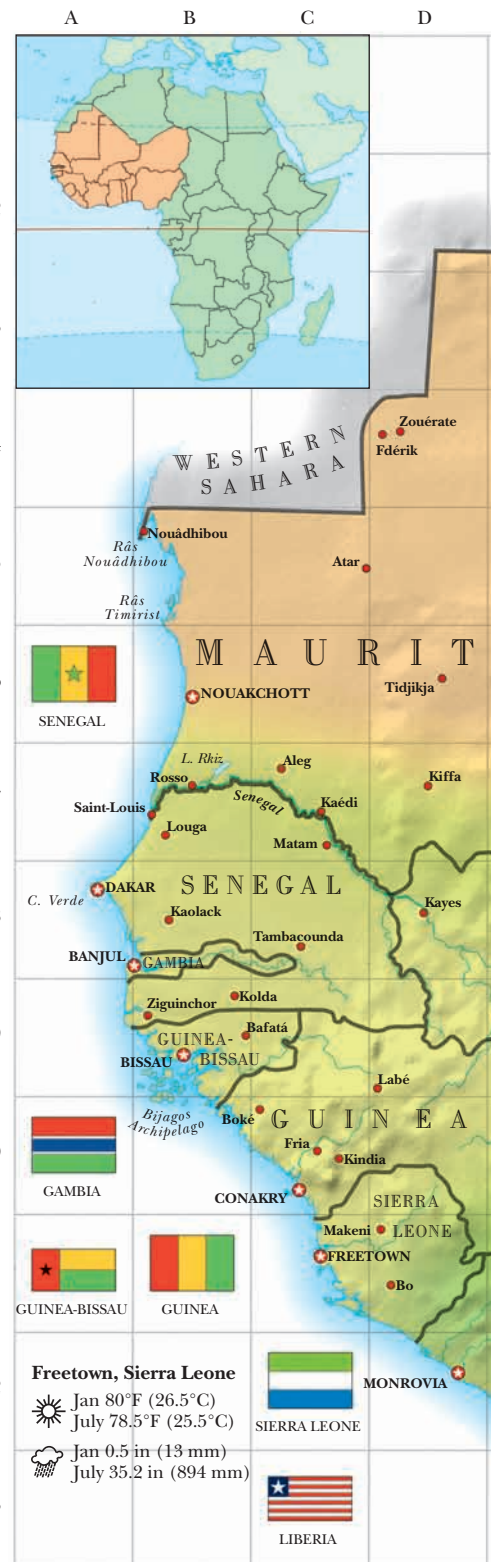
Sahel
The arid northern grasslands that border the desert are called sahel – the word means "shore" of the desert in Arabic. Few trees can survive in this region.



Savanna
Moving south, a little more rain falls in the vast expanses of savanna – grassland scattered with acacias, baobabs, and other trees. Much of West Africa consists of savanna.



Tropical forest
Moist forests flourish under the heavy rains of the far south. Many animals and plants exist here, although there are not as many different species as in the rain forests of central Africa.



WEST AFRICAN FARMERS

This region is home to two very different types of farmer – settled and nomadic. Settled farmers live near small plots of land on which they grow enough to feed their families, and perhaps grow some cash crops, such as cocoa or oil palms. Nomadic cattle herders, such as the Fulani, roam constantly across the region in search of good grazing land. They are more common toward the drier north, where the land is not as fertile for agriculture.